

Chapter 46-8

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By the time Liang Shi brought Rainbow to eat hamburgers, it was already past 8:30. She felt deeply sorry.

Moreover, Zhou Li had already returned home, so when Liang Shi sent the child back, she was surprised.

Liang Shi had originally wanted to tell the truth, but Rainbow covered for her, "Sister Liang Shi took me to see a movie."

Liang Shi: "..."

She went along with the excuse Rainbow had given her.

When Liang Shi passed by the road leading to Xu Qingzhu's company, she sent Xu Qingzhu a message asking if she had gone home yet.

Xu Qingzhu's reply was very brief: [I'm back.]

So Liang Shi drove home.

The living room lights were on, and the smell of food wafted from the house.

Liang Shi suddenly felt at peace in her heart.

But unexpectedly, as soon as she walked over, Xu Qingzhu came out of the kitchen, "What did you do today?"

Liang Shi: "...Helped a colleague pick up a child after work."

"You seem to particularly like little children," Xu Qingzhu said casually.

Liang Shi was startled, "It's... it's alright."

She did like them a bit.

Mainly because human cubs each had their own charm.

Ling Dang was sweet-talking and good at coaxing people, while Rainbow was the cool type but exceptionally considerate.

"Besides picking up the child?" Xu Qingzhu asked her.

Liang Shi hesitated, not knowing whether she should tell Xu Qingzhu about Cheng Ran and Qi Jiao.

Xu Qingzhu was exceptionally patient with her. After asking, she kept waiting for her answer, so there was no way to brush it off.

After a few seconds, Liang Shi said, "I also went to find Qi Jiao. Regarding childhood matters, she denied them, but judging from her attitude, it should be true."

"So what do you plan to do?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi thought for a moment, "I'll go back to the old mansion tomorrow."

To see Qiu Zimin.

Even if she only had to listen to those disgusting words.

She had already researched PUA¹-related materials. What Qiu Zimin had done to the original owner was definitely PUA.

PUA and abuse by parents toward their children would actually be typical Stockholm syndrome².

The children would become especially dependent on their parents and expect to gain their recognition.

They were essentially suffering abuse, but wanted to gain the abuser's approval.

Qiu Zimin was really skilled at manipulating people's hearts, and she even used feudal superstition³.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had the same thoughts - those formations wouldn't really do anything to her, but living long-term in such a depressing environment would drive a person insane if it didn't kill them.

But why was Qiu Zimin doing this?

Liang Shi planned to go back to the old mansion tomorrow to play dumb and fish for information.

"Cheng Ran contacted me today," Xu Qingzhu suddenly said. "She apologized to me and said she'd come apologize in person another day."

Liang Shi stopped thinking about the Liang family matters and answered somewhat frantically, "...That's good news."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her with determined eyes, "You did that, didn't you?"

Liang Shi: "...Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu took out her phone and showed it to her, "Unfortunately, all your whereabouts today were exposed."

Liang Shi: "?"

She looked at Xu Qingzhu's phone with complete bewilderment.

First were photos of her and Qi Jiao standing at the kindergarten entrance, taken quite ambiguously, especially the scene where she reached out to brush the leaf off Qi Jiao - it looked particularly like they were about to embrace.

Several photos showed her and Qi Jiao standing together.

Then there were photos of her and Cheng Ran, showing her throwing punches at Cheng Ran with a somewhat fierce expression.

Especially her eyes - she herself hadn't realized her gaze could be so stern.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, "Do I have the right to explain?"

Xu Qingzhu put her phone away. She hadn't shared the text messages Bai Weiwei had sent her with Liang Shi.

She only showed Liang Shi the pictures.

The text messages Bai Weiwei had sent were: [The person you've chosen is nothing special after all.]

[She's deceiving you. What do you mean she's changed for the better?]

[Look at how she hits people - how is that different from before?]

[They're all trash.]

Xu Qingzhu had already deleted those messages.

She only kept the pictures.

Xu Qingzhu smiled as she looked at her, "What do you want to explain?"

Liang Shi: "..."

After silence, she found that she actually didn't know where to start explaining.

But Xu Qingzhu shrugged and turned toward the kitchen, "Let's eat."

Liang Shi: "...?"

This wasn't right.

Xu Qingzhu brought out the dishes, then looked at the completely bewildered Liang Shi. Her clear, cold voice carried a hint of tenderness, "Teacher Liang, who sought justice for me, you've worked hard."

Footnotes:

¹ PUA: "Pick-up Artist" tactics, but in Chinese internet culture often refers to psychological manipulation and emotional abuse techniques used to control someone.

² Stockholm syndrome: A psychological phenomenon where hostages develop positive feelings toward their captors.

³ Feudal superstition (封建迷信): A term used in modern China to describe traditional beliefs and practices considered backward or unscientific, such as fortune-telling, feng shui used manipulatively, etc.